NEW-AGE SPIRITUAL LINGO

Words used on repeat by digital gurus

- **BLESSED:** It usually means being grateful...for anything from a trip to a five-star resort to a moment of enlightenment
- **VIBES:** Based on how an influencer feels about people or situations around them, classified as good or bad
- **SELF-CARE:** Anything you are doing for yourself can amount to self-care, be it a spa break, going for a walk or taking a breath
- **SELF-LOVE:** Decisions taken to emotionally stand up for yourself, like setting boundaries or demanding respect from others
- **GODDESS:** Instead of asking followers to find their inner strength, many influencers exhort them to find their inner goddess. It denotes strength, passion, glory and loyalty
- **ABUNDANCE:** This means taking time to see the positives in life, such as nature, material gifts or loved ones
- **FOLLOW YOUR BLISS:** Just do what makes you happy
- **THINK POSITIVE:** This is used in posts about karma, about attracting good outcomes in your life by having positive and virtuous thoughts
- **DFTBA (DON'T FORGET TO BE AWESOME):** A common sign-off phrase from influencers, urging followers to talk about how well they follow the spiritual path



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

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>
> **-SHREYASI WALIA**
> *Spiritual Influencer*

he explains. Driven by a need for instant gratification, many have no time for behavioural change. Instead, they are content with learning the right phrases. "People find spirituality fashionable, but won't take the final step to walk the talk. So a person might speak of forgiveness and love but behave badly," says Walia. A few get into 'spiritual shopping'—paying or follow-ing four-five purveyors for bits of advice. But when the lesson reaches a stage where it demands effort for substantive change, they shift to the next guru. "Spirituality can give people a dopamine rush," says Mumbai-based psy-chiatrist Harish Shetty. "Social media is about image-building, and following a popular influencer gives people the image they want to project."

Sadhguru and Sri Sri Ravi Shankar are the top spiritual influencers online with 10 million and 1.9 million fol-lowers on Instagram respectively. Yet, both believe online browsing alone is not enough. "Once Shankaran Pillai (an imaginary character often used by Sadhguru) went to a restaurant. Their menu ran into five-six pages. He read it and asked, 'I've read it, do I really have to eat?' There is a difference between reading the menu and eating and digesting the food. YouTube is only for learning another way to live, what kind of human being you want to be has to happen from within," says Sadhguru.

Some influencers are mindful of their followers' superficial interests, and an over-abundance of positivity to pander to them. "There's no need for positivity anymore...it is too overdone," says lifestyle influencer Sunaina Rekhi, who has 169,000 followers. "Everyone pretends to be happy online, it is almost like a contest to be happy."

Veterans see the growth of digital spirituality in a positive light as long as it doesn't dilute its essential idea. "People taking to spirituality because it is 'fashionable' or otherwise is a good sign," says Sri Sri Ravishankar. Yogacharya Prahlada of Sivananda Ashram, a disciple of the ashram's founder Swami Vishnudevananda, agrees, "We are born to be happy and that is possible only when we live with complete awareness of who we are and where we are going."

The introduction of VR technology holds the promise of more life-like spiritual communication. Perhaps one day, meditating will not involve trying to shut out urban noise. Instead, a click would simulate a forest, alive with birdsong, the whisper of a stream and the sound of falling leaves. Whether it gets one closer to enlightenment is an open question. It would, however, make for an excellent reel. ■